

Frittata with oven-dried tomatoes and Cheddar cheese

Boldly flavored tomatoes, fresh basil, and Cheddar cheese on top make this frittata a **masterful** presentation. The key to a successful frittata is to cook the eggs nice and slowly, so that they set before the bottom browns too much.

NOTE The exact number of servings depends on the size of the crowd and on whether you're offering this as a main dish along with several other items in a buffet brunch.

1 red onion, thinly sliced
3 tablespoons olive oil
4 garlic cloves, minced
¼ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper
8 free-range eggs
4 large oven-dried plum tomatoes (recipe follows), cut into quarters

½ cup grated sharp Cheddar cheese [50g]
8 or 10 fresh basil leaves, torn into small pieces
½ teaspoon salt
Freshly ground pepper
Salsa

1. In a 10- to 12-inch [26- to 30-cm] cast-iron skillet, cook the red onion in 1½ tablespoons of the olive oil over medium heat until very soft and lightly browned, about 10 minutes. **Stir** in the garlic and hot pepper and cook for 1 minute longer. Transfer to a bowl and let cool to room temperature. If you're in a rush, put in the fridge for 5 or 10 minutes.
2. Break the eggs into a large bowl and whisk until well blended. **Add** the tomatoes, Cheddar cheese, basil, salt, and a generous grinding of black pepper. Mix the ingredients thoroughly. Add the cooled onion and garlic to the eggs and mix again.

3. Preheat the broiler with the oven rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. In the same cast-iron skillet, **heat** the remaining 1½ tablespoons oil over medium heat. Add the egg mixture and evenly distribute in the pan with a fork. Lift the edges several times with a spatula and tilt the pan to let the uncooked egg run underneath. Reduce the heat to medium-low and cook for 8 to 10 minutes, or until the frittata is set around the edges but still a little wobbly in the center. Place the pan under the broiler for about 2 minutes, until lightly browned and firm on top.
4. Let the finished dish set for 5 to 10 minutes before serving. **Remove** with a spatula, carefully dislodging the egg from around the inside edge of the pan first. The frittata should slip right out onto a large plate. If it does not, slice it into quarters first. Pass a bowl of salsa on the side.

SERVES 4 TO 6

Oven-dried tomatoes

Preheat the oven to 175°F (80°C). Slice plum tomatoes lengthwise in half. Place face down on a parchment paper-lined heavy-duty baking sheet and bake at for at least 6 to 8 hours. Sun-dried tomatoes can be substituted but will not carry the day as your own freshly dried tomatoes will.